

PROJECT POLARIS

Executive roadmap to a trusted private alpha

A practical desk reference for moving from a validated hosted onboarding flow to a measured private-alpha learning loop.

NORTH STAR

Help smart-telescope users decide what to do tonight, understand why, and spend more of their limited clear time capturing.

Executive update | August 2, 2026 | Internal planning document

The shortest credible path

Polaris has passed the private-alpha onboarding checkpoint: a clean test account reached Tonight, saw its own observing home, saw no Doug data, and received a cloud-driven Do Not Image recommendation that explained the actual reason. The next step is not more broad feature work. It is to prove one repeatable habit: a smart-telescope user opens Polaris before imaging, understands the recommendation, rates whether it helped, and comes back.

CURRENT STATE	WORK CADENCE	NEXT SPRINT
V1.6 pass Hosted onboarding retest complete	10-14 hr/wk Focused sessions, not a full-time team	V1.8 Feedback + alpha scoring loop

TIMELINE

	AUGUST 2 V1.6 onboarding checkpoint	Clean account reached Tonight and saw no cross-user data.
	EARLY AUGUST V1.8 feedback + scoring	Turn Yes/No responses and tester notes into a compact alpha review loop.
	MID-LATE AUGUST V1.9 exposure + reliability	Tighten weather, Moon, tracking, heat, and 999-frame explanations.
	LATE AUGUST-SEPTEMBER First private-alpha cohort	Invite 2-5 users first; expand only after repeat-use evidence.
	AFTER ALPHA EVIDENCE Closed beta decision	Expand, narrow, extend alpha, or pause based on behavior.

The decision rule: do not publicly launch because a feature list feels complete. Launch only when real users repeatedly trust Polaris to reduce a real planning problem.

What Polaris is learning next

Dates are planning ranges. Each version exits only when the user-facing result is credible, not merely when its code compiles.

PLAIN-ENGLISH STEP	OUTCOME	EXIT TEST
V1.6 complete	Private-alpha onboarding is clear enough for the next invited tester.	Clean account saw setup first, reached Tonight, saw no Doug data, and understood cloud-driven Do Not Image.
V1.7 complete	Hosted foundation: accounts, tenant boundaries, deployment, monitoring, backup, and recovery.	Two-user isolation, privacy-safe monitoring, tenant export, and recovery drill passed.
V1.8 next	Feedback + scoring loop: turn tester responses into product decisions.	Doug can review recent recommendations, usefulness, comprehension notes, and the top next fix.
V1.9 next	Exposure and reliability logic: make conservative settings easier to trust.	Weather, Moon, tracking, heat, and 999-frame limits produce clear, conservative explanations.
V1.10 alpha	Invite the first small cohort before any broader private alpha.	2-5 users make real observing decisions and return without critical privacy or comprehension issues.
V2.0 decision	Choose whether to expand to closed beta, narrow scope, extend alpha, or pause.	Decision uses retention, trust, support burden, and willingness-to-pay evidence.

What deliberately waits: native iOS/Android apps, subscriptions, broad device support, advanced image-processing workflows, and large feature expansion. They earn their place after the alpha proves repeat use.

How we keep the mountain small

The plan should reduce overwhelm, not create more administration. We will use it to choose the next 100 feet of the climb.

Every time Doug says Start coding timer, the session begins with:

1	Current position Version, active milestone, and a short recap of what changed in the last few sessions.
2	One outcome for today One clear result sized for the available 1-2 hour session, with only the next one or two tasks.
3	Reality check Expected time, a real blocker, and the reason today matters to the private-alpha path.
4	Close the loop Test, commit when appropriate, update the timer, and name the next smallest step.

Completed foundation

DONE	Planner V3 produces chronological, equipment-aware advisory schedules.
DONE	The hosted foundation has passed account isolation, deployment, monitoring, backup, and recovery drills.
DONE	A clean hosted test account completed setup, reached Tonight, and saw no Doug data.
DONE	Cloud-driven Do Not Image decisions now name cloud cover and align the visible rating with planned-start weather.
DONE	Backup checks, startup preflight, release gates, and a running project-time log protect the local product.

Parallel business track: naming, preliminary availability checks, a domain, a simple landing page, and launch-readiness work move alongside the product. We will ask qualified professionals to review decisions with legal or tax consequences.

Project-manager commitment: I will flag scope creep, distinguish facts from guesses, and recommend the smallest useful next step.